One dataset, four decisions, 171-fold range

Each row is a choice that must be made before any viral fraction can be reported.

6 fecal metagenomes PRJNA539906 →

Denominator *what counts as 100%*	All clean reads	Host-depleted reads	Total vOTUs	**1.1×** small here — host fraction is low
Reference space *what you compare against*	RVDB-prot	Local vOTUs	Contig set	**5.6×** local DB recovers more viral reads
Evidence threshold *how much proof is required*	Any hit	Functional only	ANI + coverage	**7.1×** largest single effect here
Statistical unit *reads or fragments*	Read counts	RPKM weighted	Presence / absence	**5.4×** contig-level inflation ≠ more virus

171× overall span

Viral fraction of a gut metagenome
0.089 % — 0.122 % (strict) 0.675 % — 0.702 % (permissive)
contig level 1.4 % — 13.3 % vOTU level 2.1 % — 15.2 %

Fold ranges are measured in this dataset with the other three dimensions held fixed; they are not strictly multiplicative.